

Final Ethnographic Analysis

Over the course of my observations in the common study area of Mugar Memorial Library, my understanding of the space didn't change at once, but gradually. At first, it felt somewhat chaotic: there was noise, people moving around, occasional conversations, and a constant awareness of others. It didn't immediately feel like a highly structured environment. After spending more time there, patterns started to become clearer. What seemed disorganized at first was held together by a set of unspoken expectations that people were following without being told to.

In my earliest observations, I focused mostly on the physical environment: the fluorescent lighting, the lack of natural light, and how the seating was arranged. There were no clocks and very limited windows. This made it harder to keep track of time. The space almost felt suspended. Even so, people stayed for long periods and worked continuously. At the time, I noted that "individuals internalize the expectations of the space and monitor their own behavior," but I wasn't entirely sure what that meant yet. It felt like something was happening socially, but I couldn't fully explain it.

The interview I conducted later helped make more sense of this. The student I spoke to described the space as "in between": not fully silent, but not social either. What stood out most was when they said that people are expected to "look busy." The phrase stuck with me. It suggests that being productive here is not just about actually working, but also about appearing to work. Students seem aware of how they look to others, even if no one is explicitly watching. The same student described feeling "guilty in a good way" when seeing others work, which pushed them to stay focused. It's not just individual motivation. It's something created collectively.

This connects directly to Foucault's idea of discipline. There's no visible authority in this space telling people to be quiet or focused, but people act as if there is. At the same time, it doesn't feel like strict surveillance. It's more subtle than that. People aren't actively monitoring each other, but they are aware that certain behaviors, like being too loud, will stand out. In one example from the interview, when a group got too loud, others didn't say anything, but "everyone kind of looked up," and the group adjusted. That moment made it clear that enforcement happens through shared awareness rather than direct confrontation.

By my third journal, I started paying attention to objects, especially AirPods, which I had originally thought of as just tools for blocking out noise. But they seemed to be doing more than that. Students wearing them were less likely to be approached, and when someone did try to get their attention, they often hesitated or used gestures instead of speaking right away. Even when the AirPods weren't being used, just having them on the desk seemed to signal something—like the person was either focused or about to be. It wasn't always clear-cut, but there was a pattern.

Thinking about this through Geertz's idea of thick description helped me understand it better. On the surface, it's just people wearing headphones while studying. But when you look more closely, it becomes something else. It's part of how people manage interaction. The headphones signal availability, or lack of it, and others respond accordingly. The meaning isn't in the object itself, but in how people interpret and use it.

At the same time, this signaling doesn't always work perfectly. There were moments when people still talked to someone wearing AirPods, or when someone would take one earbud out, which made it harder to tell whether they were "available" or not. Some people also kept their AirPods visible without using them, which complicates the meaning

further. It's not a fixed system. It depends on shared understanding, and that understanding can shift depending on the situation.

My own experience in the space also changed over time. Early on, I felt out of place, especially when taking notes. I was very aware of myself and worried that I was being noticeable. But after spending more time there, I started to adjust without really thinking about it. I became quieter, more still, and more focused, basically matching the behavior around me. Looking back, that shift probably affected what I noticed as well. Once I felt more comfortable, I paid more attention to patterns rather than just distractions.

Overall, the Mugar library lounge is structured less by explicit rules and more by these kinds of shared practices. People manage their behavior in relation to others, even without direct interaction. Objects like AirPods, along with things like posture, noise level, and even eye contact, all play a role in shaping how the space works. It's not just a place for studying—it's something people are constantly producing together through small, repeated actions.